CORKTOWN AUDIO WORKS

Grading Guide v3

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Every piece is graded after its bench test, against this guide and its master photos. The grade describes the piece in hand. Grades and finish tags follow this guide and the photos, never a buyer's wording, and the same words go into the catalog, the listing and the caption.

1. Grades

Grade	Definition
Mint	No marks even up close. All functions to spec.
Excellent	Light hairlines visible only up close or under raking light. No chips, dents, cracks or veneer damage. All functions to spec.
Very Good	Wear visible at arm's length, and/or a veneer chip smaller than 1 cm². Fully functional.
Good	Obvious wear, such as veneer chips of 1 cm² or more, lifting veneer, cracked covers or hinges, or missing trim. Functional, with any quirks disclosed.
For Parts	Not working, not serviced, or failed the bench test. Sold as-is.

2. Applying the grades

Find the worst flaw on the piece: its row gives the grade. Mint and Excellent also need all functions to spec on the bench.

What the photos and the bench report show	Grade
No marks, even up close	**Mint**
Light hairlines, seen only up close or under raking light	**Excellent**
Scuffs or scratches you can see at arm's length	**Very Good**
A veneer chip smaller than 1 cm²	**Very Good**
A veneer chip of 1 cm² or more, lifting veneer, a cracked cover or hinge, or missing trim	**Good**
Not working, not serviced, or failed the bench test, however clean it looks	**For Parts**

How to look

- Up close: face near the surface, looking for it. Arm's length: about 60 cm away, in room light, without a raking light.
- Raking light: one light held low across the surface, nearly parallel to it, other lights off. It shows hairlines that room light hides.
- Chips: measure with a rule, don't guess. 1 cm² is a 1 cm square, and a chip 2 cm long and 0.5 cm wide is also 1 cm².

3. Finish tags

One tag per piece, from this list only. A new finish name needs Kofi's OK before it goes in the catalog.

Tag	What it looks like
Walnut	Walnut veneer or solid walnut. Dark brown, mostly straight grain.
Teak	Teak veneer. Golden to orange-brown, fine straight grain.
Rosewood	Rosewood veneer. Deep red-brown with dark figure and black streaks.
Oak	Oak veneer. Light, open grain with visible pores.
Wood-grain vinyl	Printed vinyl wrap over particleboard. Check back edges and corners for a seam.
Silver	Brushed or satin aluminium faceplate.
Black	Black faceplate or black cabinet.
Champagne	Gold-toned or champagne faceplate.

Judging the finish

- Judge wood in daylight or under the 5000K panel. Tungsten light makes walnut read warm, close to teak.
- If one photo reads differently from the rest, check the light it was shot in before changing a tag.
- Wood-grain vinyl: the printed grain repeats, and the seam usually sits on a back edge. Real veneer shows a cut edge at the corners.
- On a faceplate, judge the metal itself, not the dial glass or the knobs.

4. Master photos

- 4 to 6 per piece, numbered photo_1 to photo_6, filed in the Masters folder under the SKU.
- Shoot after the bench test and the clean-up, in daylight or under the 5000K panel. No on-camera flash.
- Receivers: one raking-light shot of the top.
- Every flaw that sets the grade gets a photo that shows it.
- When a tag and the master photos disagree, the photos win and the tag gets fixed.

5. Listings and corrections

- Use the grade and finish words exactly as written here.
- Name every flaw, even on an Excellent piece: what it is, where it is, and its photo ("see photo 5").
- A grade or finish correction never changes the price. Prices are Kofi's call.

Graded honestly. Built to last.

Version 3, revised 2026-01-10. Replaces all earlier versions of this guide.